

Session 28: Joseph's Future Hope

Key Takeaways

- The pattern of migrations in Genesis, as Abraham and his descendants move up and down from Canaan, reflects the pattern of moving from blessing to exile to redemption woven throughout the Hebrew Bible.
- Yoseph's request for his bones to be taken up to Canaan is a prophetic declaration of hope and trust in God's promises to bring life and blessing to the world.

Yoseph's Request and Death

²² And Yoseph **dwelt in Egypt**, he and the house of his father,
and Yoseph lived one hundred and ten years,
²³ and Yoseph saw for **Ephraim** sons of three generations,
also the sons of Makir, son of **Manasseh** were born on the knees of Yoseph.

²⁴ And Yoseph said to his brothers,
"I am about to **die**,
and Elohim will most certainly visit you all,
and he will bring up you all from this land,
into the land which **he swore on oath** to Avraham, to Yitskhaq, and to Ya'akov."

²⁵ And Yoseph made the sons of Yisra'el **swear an oath**, saying,
"Elohim will most certainly visit you all,
and you all will bring up my bones from this place."

²⁶ **And Yoseph died**, **a son of one hundred and ten years**.
And they embalmed him,
and **they set him in a box in Egypt**.

Genesis 50:22-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Like Father, Like Son, in Life and in Death

Yoseph's deathbed scene has been designed to parallel the deathbed scene of his father Yaaqov. The following chart makes the verbal similarities clear.

Yaaqov's Death Scene: Genesis 48:21-22	Yoseph's Death Scene: Genesis 50:24
And Israel said to Yoseph, " Behold I am about to die , and God will be with you and he will return you all to the land of your fathers."	And Yoseph said to his brothers, " I am about to die , and God will surely visit you all and he will make you all go up from this land to the land he swore to Abraham, Isaac, and Yaaqov."
Gen. 50:5 My father made me swear an oath ... you will bury me in the grave which I dug for myself in the land of Canaan .	Gen. 50:24 "God will surely visit you and he will make you go up from this land to the land which he swore on oath to Abraham, Isaac, and to Yaaqov."
Gen. 50:6 And Pharaoh said, " Go up and bury your father just as he made you swear an oath ."	Gen. 50:25 And Yoseph made the sons of Israel swear an oath saying, "God will surely visit you and you will make my bones go up from here ."
Gen. 50:7, 9 And Yoseph went up to bury his father and the servants of Pharaoh went up with him. ... And there went up with him chariots and horsemen."	
<i>Jacob and Joseph's Deaths. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yaaqov makes Yoseph swear an oath to "go up" to the land with his corpse, to bury him with his forefathers. // Yoseph makes his brothers swear an oath to "go up" to the land with his bones when God visits them. This is all about the hope of resurrection (corpse and bones) linked to the end of exile and return to the promised land (Ezek. 36-37!!).

- Yaaqov's corpse "going up" by the son. // Yoseph's bones "going up" by the brothers.
- This is an inverted Aqedah scheme: The son who swears on oath (Gen. 22:16) to make his father's corpse "go up" (עלה, Gen. 22:3, 7-8, 13, 22) from exile to the promised land. // The son makes his brothers swear on oath to make his bones "go up" from exile to the promised land.

Yoseph's Bones and the Pre-Exodus

Yoseph's "pre-exodus" from Egypt in partnership with Pharaoh is portrayed as a strong contrast to the later exodus that will be resisted by Pharaoh.

Pharaoh and Yoseph in Genesis 50	Pharaoh and Moses
Gen. 50:9-10 Pharaoh generously provides “chariots” (רכב) and horsemen (פרשים) and “a very heavy camp” (מחנה כבד מאד)	Exod. 12:38 The Israelites leave Egypt “with flocks and herds, and very heavy flocks (מקנה כבד מאד)” Exod. 14:23-24 Pharaoh chases after Israel with his “chariots” (רכב) and horsemen (פרשים), as “the camp of Egypt” (מחנה מצרים)
Gen. 50:1-14 Yoseph carries the body of Yaaqov out of Egypt Gen. 50:24-25 Yoseph predicts that “God will surely visit you” (פקד יפקד), and he made them swear an oath “that you will take up my bones from there”	Exod. 13:19 Moses carries the bones of Yoseph out of Egypt “for he made the sons of Israel swear an oath saying, ‘God will surely visit you (פקד יפקד), and you will take my bones from there with you.’”
<i>Pharaoh Dealing with Joseph and Moses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

This is part of a much larger strategy throughout [Genesis 40-50](#) and [Exodus 1-14](#) to portray the two pharaohs as contrasting opposites: The Pharaoh in Yoseph’s day recognizes the promised seed and “blessed” him and experiences blessing in return. The Pharaoh in Moses’ day plays the role of the snake and tries to destroy the promised seed, and he finds himself cursed and destroyed in the process.

Reflection Question

In what way does Yoseph’s burial request act as a prophetic image for the shape of the rest of the Hebrew Bible?